

1 Distributional Properties of Categorical Processes

1.1 General Notation

Let (X_t) be a *categorical* time series process, where each X_t takes values in

$$S := \{s_0, \dots, s_m\}, \quad m \in \mathbb{N}.$$

(X_t) may be *nominal*, in which case the order of magnitude of the elements in S is arbitrary and solely used for notational consistency, or *ordinal*, in which case the order of the elements in S reflects the inherent order of the elements.

1.2 Stationarity

Furthermore, (X_t) is assumed to be stationary. A distinction can be made between two forms of stationarity:

Definition 1.1 (Weak Stationarity). A process (X_t) is said to be *weakly stationary* if:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}(X_t) &= \mu_X & \forall t, \\ \mathbb{E}(X_t^2) &< \infty & \forall t, \\ \text{Cov}(X_t, X_{t+h}) &= \gamma(h) & \forall t, h. \end{aligned}$$

Definition 1.2 (Strong/ Strict Stationarity). Strong/ Strict stationarity requires that all finite-dimensional distributions are invariant under time shifts, i.e.,

$$F_{X_t, \dots, X_{t+j}} = F_{X_{t+h}, \dots, X_{t+h+j}} \quad \forall t, j, h. \quad (1.1)$$

1.3 Marginal Distributions

Regardless of whether we consider a simple categorical process with few categories or attempt to describe a complex, temporally evolving process using moments and measures of serial dependence, the analysis of categorical processes is always built on the examination of the marginal probabilities. However, because ordinal and nominal data encode different types of information, their marginals are typically represented in different ways:

- **Ordinal data:** Most analytical tools for ordinal processes take into account the natural ordering of the elements in S . For this reason, most methods for ordinal data rely on the marginal cumulative distribution function (CDF), which accumulates probabilities in accordance with the natural ordering of the categories:

$$\mathbf{f} = (f_0, \dots, f_{m-1})^\top, \quad f_i := P(X_t \leq s_i).$$

For ordinal data, it is sufficient to consider the cumulative probabilities of the categories $0, \dots, m-1$ since the cumulative probability of the last category m is always equal to 1.

Although one could equivalently estimate the PMF and derive the CDF from it, representing ordinal data through the CDF is often more convenient as it this form that is used to compute metrics for location and dispersion.

- **Nominal data:** Since the categories of nominal variables do not possess a meaningful order, statistical procedures cannot make use of cumulative structure. Therefore the marginal distribution is best represented by the probability mass function (PMF):

$$\mathbf{p} = (p_0, \dots, p_m)^\top, \quad p_i := P(X_t = s_i).$$

1.4 Bivariate Probabilities at Lag h

Definition 1.3 (Bivariate lag- h probabilities). Let (X_t) be a stationary categorical time series. The bivariate lag- h probabilities are defined as follows.

(i) **Ordinal series:**

$$f_{ij}(h) := P(X_t \leq s_i, X_{t+h} \leq s_j), \quad i, j = 0, \dots, m-1.$$

(ii) **Nominal series:**

$$p_{ij}(h) := P(X_t = s_i, X_{t+h} = s_j), \quad i, j = 0, \dots, m.$$

Under serial independence, the bivariate probabilities factorize as $f_{ij}(h) = f_i f_j$ and $p_{ij}(h) = p_i p_j$ respectively.

1.5 Location

For a nominal process, any measure that relies on ordering is inappropriate. Instead, a location measure must depend only on the category probabilities. The mode, defined as the most probable category,

$$\text{Mod}(X_t) = \arg \max_{s_i \in S} P(X_t = s_i),$$

is therefore the natural choice. It provides a meaningful summary of the process by identifying the most frequent category.

For an ordinal process, the natural ordering of the categories allows for additional measures of central tendency. While the mode can still be informative as the most frequent category, the median respects the ordering of categories and is often more useful for describing the central location:

$$\text{Med}(X_t) = \min\left\{s_i \in S : F(s_i) \geq \frac{1}{2}\right\}.$$

Thus, for ordinal data, both the mode and the median carry information, but they capture slightly different aspects of location: the mode identifies the most typical category, whereas the median indicates the midpoint in the ordered scale.

1.6 Measures of Dispersion

Since the concept of dispersion differs between ordinal and nominal processes, two separate measures are employed: the *Index of Ordinal Variation* (IOV) for ordinal data and the *Index of Qualitative Variation* (IQV) for nominal data, defined as

$$\text{IOV}(\mathbf{f}) = \frac{4}{m} \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} f_i(1 - f_i), \quad \text{IQV}(\mathbf{p}) = \frac{m+1}{m} \left(1 - \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2\right). \quad (1.2)$$

Both indices are scaled to $[0, 1]$, with 0 indicating a degenerate (one-point) distribution and 1 indicating maximal dispersion. However, what constitutes maximal dispersion differs: for ordinal data, dispersion is maximal when all probability mass is concentrated in the two outermost categories, whereas for nominal data it corresponds to the uniform distribution over all $m+1$ categories.

Proposition 1.4 (Dispersion Bounds). *Both IOV and IQV satisfy:*

- (i) $\text{IOV} = 0$ (resp. $\text{IQV} = 0$) if and only if the distribution is degenerate.
- (ii) $\text{IOV} = 1$ iff $\mathbf{f} = (\frac{1}{2}, \dots, \frac{1}{2})^\top$; $\text{IQV} = 1$ iff $p_i = \frac{1}{m+1}$ for all i .

Proof. Part (i), ordinal case. A one-point distribution assigns all probability mass to a single category $s_j \in S$. For ordinal data, this corresponds to a CDF vector $\mathbf{f}$ of the form

$$\mathbf{f} \in \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \dots, \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} \right\} := \{\mathbf{c}_0, \dots, \mathbf{c}_m\} \subset [0, 1]^{m+1}.$$

In each of these cases, every component f_i satisfies $f_i \in \{0, 1\}$, and thus

$$f_i(1 - f_i) = 0 \quad \forall i.$$

Therefore,

$$\text{IOV} = \frac{4}{m} \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} f_i(1 - f_i) = 0.$$

Conversely, if $\text{IOV} = 0$, then

$$\sum_{i=0}^{m-1} f_i(1 - f_i) = 0,$$

and since each term is nonnegative,

$$f_i(1 - f_i) \stackrel{!}{=} 0 \quad \forall i.$$

This is only possible if $f_i \in \{0, 1\}$ for all i , which implies $\mathbf{f} \in \{\mathbf{e}_0, \dots, \mathbf{e}_m\}$. Hence, $\text{IOV} = 0$ holds *exactly* for a degenerate one-point distributions.

Part (i), nominal case. A degenerate (one-point) distribution assigns all probability mass to a single category $s_j \in S$, which corresponds to a PMF vector of the form

$$\mathbf{p} \in \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \dots, \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} \right\} := \{\mathbf{e}_0, \dots, \mathbf{e}_m\} \subset [0, 1]^{m+1}.$$

In each of these cases, exactly one component equals 1 and all others equal 0, so

$$\sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2 = 1.$$

Thus,

$$\text{IQV} = \frac{m+1}{m} \left(1 - \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2 \right) = \frac{m+1}{m} (1 - 1) = 0.$$

Conversely, if $\text{IQV} = 0$, then

$$\frac{m+1}{m} \left(1 - \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2 \right) = 0 \implies \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2 = 1.$$

As all probabilities satisfy $0 \leq p_i \leq 1$, it follows that

$$p_i^2 \leq p_i \quad \forall p_i, \text{ and } p_i^2 < p_i \quad \forall p_i \notin \{0, 1\}.$$

Since $\sum_{i=1}^m p_i = 1$, it follows that the only way $\sum_i p_i^2 = 1$ can hold is if exactly one p_i equals 1 and all others are 0. In other words, the distribution is degenerate and $\mathbf{p} \in \{\mathbf{e}_0, \dots, \mathbf{e}_m\}$.

Part (ii), ordinal case. Dispersion of an ordinal variable is maximal when half of the probability mass lies in the lowest category and half in the highest category; with all intermediate categories having probability zero. This results in a CDF vector,

$$\mathbf{f} = \left(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, \dots, \frac{1}{2} \right)^\top.$$

Then

$$f_i(1 - f_i) = \frac{1}{2} \left(1 - \frac{1}{2}\right) = \frac{1}{4} \quad \forall i,$$

and thus

$$\text{IOV} = \frac{4}{m} \cdot \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} \frac{1}{4} = \frac{4}{m} \cdot \frac{m}{4} = 1.$$

To show that $\text{IOV} = 1 \Rightarrow \mathbf{f} = (\frac{1}{2}, \dots, \frac{1}{2})^T$, recall that the IOV only depends on $\mathbf{f}$ through the sum

$$\sum_{i=0}^{m-1} f_i(1 - f_i).$$

Taking the derivative of $g(f_i) := f_i(1 - f_i)$ and setting it to zero yields:

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial}{\partial f_i} g(f_i) &= 1 - 2f_i, \\ 1 - 2f_i &\stackrel{!}{=} 0, \\ f_i &= \frac{1}{2}. \end{aligned}$$

Since $g(f_i = 0) = g(f_i = 1) = 0$, the function is concave and this critical point is indeed the global maximum. Since it has been already shown that $\text{IOV}(\mathbf{f} = (\frac{1}{2}, \dots, \frac{1}{2})^T) = 1$, it directly follows that

$$\text{IOV}(\mathbf{f}) = 1 \Leftrightarrow \mathbf{f} = \left(\frac{1}{2}, \dots, \frac{1}{2}\right)^\top$$

Part (ii), nominal case. For nominal data, maximal dispersion is attained when probability mass is distributed uniformly across all $m + 1$ categories, i.e.

$$p_i = \frac{1}{m + 1}, \quad i = 0, \dots, m.$$

In this case,

$$\sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2 = (m + 1) \frac{1}{(m + 1)^2} = \frac{1}{m + 1},$$

and hence

$$\text{IQV} = \frac{m + 1}{m} \left(1 - \frac{1}{m + 1}\right) = 1.$$

Conversely, suppose that $\text{IQV} = 1$. Then

$$\frac{m + 1}{m} \left(1 - \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2\right) = 1 \quad \Rightarrow \quad \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2 = \frac{1}{m + 1}.$$

Thus, maximizing IQV is equivalent to minimizing

$$f(\mathbf{p}) := \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2 \quad \text{subject to} \quad \sum_{i=0}^m p_i = 1.$$

Introducing the Lagrangian (with Lagrange multiplier λ)

$$\mathcal{L}(\mathbf{p}, \lambda) := \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2 - \lambda \left(\sum_{i=0}^m p_i - 1 \right),$$

the first-order conditions are

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial p_j} &= 2p_j - \lambda = 0 \\ \Rightarrow \quad 2p_j &= \lambda, \quad j = 0, \dots, m, \end{aligned}$$

together with the constraint $\sum_{i=0}^m p_i = 1$. Since the same multiplier λ applies to all components, it follows that

$$p_0 = p_1 = \dots = p_m.$$

Imposing the constraint yields

$$(m+1)p_j = 1 \quad \Rightarrow \quad p_j = \frac{1}{m+1} \quad \forall j \in 0, \dots, m.$$

Hence, $f(\mathbf{p})$ is uniquely minimized at

$$\mathbf{p} = \left(\frac{1}{m+1}, \dots, \frac{1}{m+1} \right)^\top,$$

and therefore IQV attains its maximal value at the uniform distribution. □

1.7 Measures of serial dependence

The marginal distribution of a categorical time series captures the long-run frequencies of the individual categories, but contains no information about the temporal structure of the process. To describe how the process evolves over time, measures of serial dependence are required.

For continuous-valued processes, the autocorrelation function (ACF) is the standard tool for quantifying temporal dependence. However, the ACF is not directly applicable to categorical data, since it relies on the existence of meaningful arithmetic operations on the observed values. For nominal data, such operations are undefined, and for ordinal data they are questionable, as the categories carry no numerical meaning beyond their ordering.

Dependence measures for categorical time series are typically constructed from the bivariate lag- h probabilities introduced in definition 1.3. Under serial independence, these would factorize as $f_{ij}(h) = f_i f_j$ and $p_{ij}(h) = p_i p_j$ respectively. Measures for serial dependence are naturally constructed by quantifying the deviation of the bivariate probabilities from this independence benchmark.

Natural and widely used measures in this context are the ordinal and nominal version of

Cohen's κ , which compare the joint probabilities to those expected under independence. For a lag- h process, they are defined as

$$\kappa_{\text{ord}}(h) = \frac{\sum_{j=0}^{m-1} (f_{jj}(h) - f_j^2)}{\sum_{i=0}^{m-1} f_i(1 - f_i)}, \quad \text{and} \quad \kappa_{\text{nom}}(h) = \frac{\sum_{j=0}^m (p_{jj}(h) - p_j^2)}{1 - \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2}.$$

The numerator of each measure sums the diagonal deviations $f_{jj}(h) - f_j^2$ (resp. $p_{jj}(h) - p_j^2$), which capture the excess probability of observing the same category at times t and $t + h$ relative to what would be expected under independence. The denominator normalizes the numerator by a measure of marginal dispersion: for the ordinal version it equals $\frac{m}{4} \cdot \text{IOV}$, and for the nominal version it is equal to $\frac{m}{m+1} \cdot \text{IQV}$. This ensures that $\kappa(h)$ is invariant to the overall level of dispersion in the marginal distribution. For both measures, positive values indicate that the process tends to remain in the same category across lag h , while negative values indicate a tendency to switch categories.

Under perfect positive dependence, i.e. $P(X_{t+h} = s_i | X_t = s_i) = 1$ for all $s_i \in S$, we have $f_{jj}(h) = f_j$ and $p_{jj}(h) = p_j$, and both measures attain their upper bound:

$$\begin{aligned} \kappa_{\text{ord}}(h) &= \frac{\sum_{j=0}^{m-1} (f_j - f_j^2)}{\sum_{i=0}^{m-1} (f_i - f_i^2)} = 1, \\ \kappa_{\text{nom}}(h) &= \frac{\sum_{j=0}^m (p_j - p_j^2)}{1 - \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2} = \frac{1 - \sum_{j=0}^m p_j^2}{1 - \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2} = 1. \end{aligned}$$

Under serial independence, $f_{jj}(h) = f_j^2$ and $p_{jj}(h) = p_j p_j$, so that the numerator vanishes and $\kappa(h) = 0$.

For the nominal version, the lower bound is attained when $p_{jj}(h) = 0$ for all j , i.e. when the process never remains in the same category across lag h :

$$\kappa_{\text{nom}}(h) = \frac{-\sum_{j=0}^m p_j^2}{1 - \sum_{i=0}^m p_i^2},$$

which depends on the marginal distribution and equals -1 only in the special case of a uniform marginal. For the ordinal version, the lower bound takes an analogous form but involves the cumulative probabilities f_j .

2 Samples Measures

2.1 Estimation of Marginal Distributions

To estimate the marginal (cumulative) probabilities, we express the relative frequencies through a binarization of the original process (X_t) . For ordinal data, define the indicator vector

$$\mathbf{Z}_t := (Z_{t,0}, \dots, Z_{t,m-1})^\top, \quad Z_{t,i} := \mathbb{I}\{X_t \leq s_i\},$$

and for nominal data analogously

$$\mathbf{Y}_t := (Y_{t,0}, \dots, Y_{t,m})^\top, \quad Y_{t,i} := \mathbb{I}\{X_t = s_i\}.$$

The marginal CDF and PMF vectors are estimated by the corresponding sample means:

Definition 2.1 (Empirical CDF and PMF estimators).

$$\hat{\mathbf{f}} := \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbf{Z}_t, \quad \hat{\mathbf{p}} := \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbf{Y}_t.$$

2.2 Asymptotics of the marginal estimator

To derive the asymptotic distribution of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}$ and $\hat{\mathbf{p}}$, a central limit theorem for dependent data is required. Since independence is not assumed, we impose weak dependence conditions on the original process (X_t) .

Specifically, $(X_t)_{t \in \mathbb{Z}}$ is assumed to be strictly stationary and α -mixing with exponentially decaying coefficients.

Definition 2.2 (α -Mixing with Exponential Decay). Following Bradley (2005), let

$$\mathcal{F}_J^L := \sigma(X_t : J \leq t \leq L)$$

denote the σ -field generated by $\{X_t : J \leq t \leq L\}$. The α -mixing coefficients of (X_t) , given that it's strictly stationary, are defined as

$$\alpha_{X_t}(n) := \sup_{A \in \mathcal{F}_{-\infty}^0, B \in \mathcal{F}_n^\infty} |P(A \cap B) - P(A)P(B)|.$$

The process is called α -mixing if $\alpha(n) \rightarrow 0$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$.

We additionally assume exponential decay of the mixing coefficients, i.e., there exist constants $C > 0$ and $\rho \in (0, 1)$ such that

$$\alpha(n) \leq C\rho^n \quad \text{for all } n \in \mathbb{N}. \quad (2.1)$$

The indicator mappings

$$g_i(X_t) := \mathbb{I}\{X_t \leq s_i\}, \quad h_i(X_t) := \mathbb{I}\{X_t = s_i\},$$

are measurable functions of X_t (see Klenke, 2005, p. 34). Since measurability preserves strict stationarity, the binarized processes $(g_i(X_t))$ and $(h_i(X_t))$ are strictly stationary whenever (X_t) is strictly stationary (see Kallenberg, 2002, p. 558). Consequently, the vector-valued processes $\mathbf{Z}_t$ and $\mathbf{Y}_t$ are strictly stationary as well.

Moreover, each indicator variable $Z_{t,i}$ is defined on the same probability space as X_t , and the σ -field it generates satisfies

$$\sigma(Z_{t,i} : J \leq t \leq L) \subset \sigma(X_t : J \leq t \leq L), \quad J \leq L,$$

which implies $\alpha_{Z_{t,i}}(n) \leq \alpha_{X_t}(n)$ for all i and n . Hence, $\mathbf{Z}_t$ and $\mathbf{Y}_t$ are also α -mixing with exponentially decaying coefficients.

To derive the asymptotic distribution of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}$, we apply the Cramér–Wold device: $\hat{\mathbf{f}}$ converges in distribution to a multivariate normal if and only if every scalar projection

$$U_t := \mathbf{a}^\top \mathbf{Z}_t, \quad \mathbf{a} \in \mathbb{R}^m \setminus \{\mathbf{0}\},$$

satisfies a univariate CLT. To see that U_t is measurable, let

$$L : \mathbb{R}^{m+1} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad L(\mathbf{z}) = \mathbf{a}^\top \mathbf{z}.$$

Since L is linear on a finite-dimensional space, it is continuous and therefore (Borel-)measurable. The vector-valued function $g(X_t) = \mathbf{Z}_t$ is measurable due to the measurability of its components, so the composition

$$U_t = L \circ g \circ X_t$$

is also measurable. Hence U_t inherits strict stationarity and α -mixing with $\alpha_{U_t}(n) \leq \alpha_{X_t}(n) \leq C\rho^n$ from (X_t) . We apply the CLT of Ibragimov (1962, Theorem 7), which requires four conditions:

- (i) **Strict stationarity.** Verified above, as U_t is a measurable function of the strictly stationary process (X_t) .
- (ii) **α -mixing.** Verified above, with $\alpha_{U_t}(n) \leq C\rho^n$.
- (iii) **Summability.** The mixing coefficients are required to satisfy

$$\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \alpha(n)^{\lambda/(2+\lambda)} < \infty \quad \text{for some } \lambda > 0.$$

Under exponential decay $\alpha(n) \leq C\rho^n$, this follows from

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \alpha(n)^{\lambda/(2+\lambda)} &\leq C^{\lambda/(2+\lambda)} \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \rho^{n\lambda/(2+\lambda)} \\ &= C^{\lambda/(2+\lambda)} \frac{\rho^{\lambda/(2+\lambda)}}{1 - \rho^{\lambda/(2+\lambda)}} < \infty, \end{aligned}$$

since $0 < \rho^{\lambda/(2+\lambda)} < 1$ for all $\lambda > 0$.

- (iv) **Moment condition.** The theorem requires $E|U_t|^{2+\lambda} < \infty$ for some $\lambda > 0$. Since each $Z_{t,i} \in \{0, 1\}$, the projection U_t is bounded by $M := \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} |a_i| < \infty$, and hence $E|U_t|^{2+\lambda} \leq M^{2+\lambda} < \infty$ for all $\lambda > 0$.

All four conditions being satisfied, Ibragimov's CLT applies to (U_t) , and by the Cramér–Wold device, the asymptotic variance matrix $\Sigma_Z = (\sigma_{Z;i,j})$ is determined by

$$\mathbf{a}^\top \Sigma_Z \mathbf{a} = \text{Var}(U_t) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \text{Cov}(U_t, U_{t+h}),$$

which gives

$$\sigma_{Z;i,j} = \text{Cov}(Z_{t,i}, Z_{t,j}) + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} [\text{Cov}(Z_{t,i}, Z_{t+h,j}) + \text{Cov}(Z_{t,j}, Z_{t+h,i})].$$

Using $\text{Cov}(Z_{t,i}, Z_{t,j}) = f_{\min\{i,j\}} - f_i f_j$ and $\text{Cov}(Z_{t,i}, Z_{t+h,j}) = f_{ij}(h) - f_i f_j$, the elements of Σ_Z take the explicit form

$$\sigma_{Z;i,j} = (f_{\min\{i,j\}} - f_i f_j) + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} (f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j).$$

Theorem 2.3 (Asymptotic Normality of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}$). *Let (X_t) be strictly stationary and α -mixing with exponentially decaying coefficients. Then*

$$\sqrt{n}(\hat{\mathbf{f}} - \mathbf{f}) \xrightarrow[n \rightarrow \infty]{d} \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, \Sigma_Z),$$

where $\Sigma_Z = (\sigma_{Z;i,j})_{i,j=0,\dots,m-1}$ is given by

$$\sigma_{Z;i,j} = (f_{\min\{i,j\}} - f_i f_j) + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} (f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j). \quad (2.2)$$

2.3 Asymptotic Properties of Sample Dispersion Measures

IOV

We can now use this information of the asymptotic distribution of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}$ to compute the asymptotic properties of sample measures that are based on $\hat{\mathbf{f}}$. According to the multivariate delta-method a random variable $G^* := g^*(\Theta^*)$, where $\Theta^* \in \mathbb{R}^m$, $\sqrt{n}(\Theta^* - \Theta) \overset{asy.}{\sim} \mathcal{N}(0, \Sigma^*)$ and $g^* : \mathbb{R}^m \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is a continuously differentiable function, satisfies

$$\sqrt{n}(G^* - g^*(\Theta)) \overset{asy.}{\sim} \mathcal{N}(0, \mathbf{j} \Sigma^* \mathbf{j}^\top)$$

where $\mathbf{j}$ is the one-dimensional Jacobian-matrix (i.e. vector) and where $j_i = \frac{\partial g^*(\Theta)}{\partial \theta_i}$. Since we have shown that $\hat{\mathbf{f}}$ is asymptotically normal we can use this to derive the

asymptotic properties of sample measures like the IOV. The respective Jacobian is given by:

$$\mathbf{j}_{\text{IOV}} = \left(\frac{\partial \text{IOV}(\mathbf{f})}{\partial f_0}, \dots, \frac{\partial \text{IOV}(\mathbf{f})}{\partial f_{m-1}} \right) = \frac{4}{m} ((1 - 2f_0), \dots, (1 - 2f_{m-1}))$$

which leads to an asymptotic variance of the IOV:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Var}(\widehat{\text{IOV}}(\mathbf{f})) &\stackrel{\text{asy.}}{=} \mathbf{j}_{\text{IOV}} \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\mathbf{Z}} \mathbf{j}_{\text{IOV}}^\top = \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} \sum_{j=0}^{m-1} \frac{4(1 - 2f_i)}{m} \frac{4(1 - 2f_j)}{m} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z};i,j} \\ &= \frac{16}{m^2} \sum_{i,j=0}^{m-1} (1 - 2f_i)(1 - 2f_j) \sigma_{\mathbf{Z};i,j} \end{aligned}$$

However, since IOV is not a linear function, the first-order delta method only provides information about the asymptotic distribution and variance, not on the finite-sample bias:

$$(\widehat{\text{IOV}} \xrightarrow{p} \text{IOV}(\mathbf{f})) \not\Rightarrow (\mathbb{E}[\widehat{\text{IOV}}] = \text{IOV}(\mathbf{f})).$$

For nonlinear transformations, the curvature induces a bias of order n^{-1} . Since $\text{IOV}(\mathbf{f}) = \frac{4}{m} \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} f_i(1 - f_i)$ is quadratic in $\mathbf{f}$, all derivatives of order three and higher vanish identically. Consequently, the second-order Taylor expansion is not merely an approximation but exact:

$$\text{IOV}(\hat{\mathbf{f}}) = \text{IOV}(\mathbf{f}) + \mathbf{j}_{\text{IOV}}(\hat{\mathbf{f}} - \mathbf{f}) + \frac{1}{2}(\hat{\mathbf{f}} - \mathbf{f})^\top \mathbf{H}_{\text{IOV}}(\mathbf{f})(\hat{\mathbf{f}} - \mathbf{f}),$$

with no remainder term. $\mathbf{H}_{\text{IOV}}(\mathbf{f})$ is the Hessian matrix such that

$$\mathbf{H}_{\text{IOV}}(\mathbf{f}) = \left(\frac{\partial^2 \text{IOV}(\mathbf{f})}{\partial f_i \partial f_j} \right)_{i,j=0,\dots,m-1} = \begin{cases} -\frac{8}{m} & \text{if } i = j \\ 0 & \text{else} \end{cases} = -\frac{8}{m} \mathbf{I}_m.$$

Since

$$\mathbb{E}(\mathbf{j}_{\text{IOV}}(\hat{\mathbf{f}} - \mathbf{f})) = 0$$

the finite sample bias is given by

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Bias}(\text{IOV}(\hat{\mathbf{f}})) &= \mathbb{E} \left[\frac{1}{2}(\hat{\mathbf{f}} - \mathbf{f})^\top \mathbf{H}_{\text{IOV}}(\mathbf{f})(\hat{\mathbf{f}} - \mathbf{f}) \right] \\ &= \frac{1}{2} \text{tr} \left(\mathbf{H}_{\text{IOV}} \text{Cov}(\hat{\mathbf{f}}) \right) \quad \mathbb{E}(\mathbf{u}^\top \mathbf{A} \mathbf{u}) = \text{tr}(\mathbf{A} \text{Cov}(\mathbf{u})) \\ &= -\frac{1}{n} \frac{4}{m} \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z};i,i}. \end{aligned}$$

This implies that the bias is strictly negative and only depends on the marginal variances $\sigma_{\mathbf{Z};i,i}$ of the individual estimators f_i , not on the covariances. The results are summarized in the following theorem:

Theorem 2.4 (Asymptotic Distribution of $\widehat{\text{IOV}}$). *Under the assumptions of Theorem 2.3:*

(i) **Asymptotic variance:**

$$\text{Var}(\widehat{\text{IOV}}) \stackrel{\text{asy.}}{=} \frac{16}{m^2} \sum_{i,j=0}^{m-1} (1 - 2f_i)(1 - 2f_j) \sigma_{Z;i,j}. \quad (2.3)$$

(ii) **Bias to order n^{-1} :**

$$\text{Bias}(\widehat{\text{IOV}}) = -\frac{4}{m n} \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} \sigma_{Z;i,i}. \quad (2.4)$$

Skewness

In a similar way the asymptotic properties of other dispersion metrics such as the skew can be analyzed. A simple measure for the skew of an ordinal process is given by:

$$\text{skew}(\mathbf{f}) = \frac{2}{m} \left(\sum_{i=0}^{m-1} f_i \right) - 1.$$

The measure captures asymmetry through the average level of the CDF: A symmetric distribution is taken as baseline and deviations from this baseline reflect asymmetry in the distribution. The measure is scaled to $[-1, 1]$, and the three extreme cases illustrate its behavior clearly:

- **Left-skewed** (skew = 1): all probability mass is concentrated in the lowest category s_0 , so $f_i = 1$ for all i and skew = $\frac{2}{m} \cdot m - 1 = 1$.
- **Symmetric** (skew = 0): the distribution is symmetric around the midpoint, which implies $f_i + f_{m-1-i} = 1$ for all i . It follows that $\sum_{i=0}^{m-1} f_i = m/2$ and skew = $\frac{2}{m} \cdot \frac{m}{2} - 1 = 0$.
- **Right-skewed** (skew = -1): all probability mass is concentrated in the highest category s_m , so $f_i = 0$ for all $i < m$ and skew = $\frac{2}{m} \cdot 0 - 1 = -1$.

The jacobian for the skew is given by

$$\mathbf{j}_{\text{skew}} = \left(\frac{\partial \text{skew}(\mathbf{f})}{\partial f_0}, \dots, \frac{\partial \text{skew}(\mathbf{f})}{\partial f_{m-1}} \right) = \left(\frac{2}{m}, \dots, \frac{2}{m} \right)$$

such that we end up with the following results:

Proposition 2.5 (Asymptotic Properties of $\widehat{\text{skew}}$). *Under the assumptions of Theorem 2.3:*

$$\text{Var}(\widehat{\text{skew}}) \stackrel{\text{asy.}}{=} \frac{4}{n m^2} \sum_{i,j=0}^{m-1} \sigma_{Z;i,j}. \quad (2.5)$$

Since skew is linear in $\mathbf{f}$, the Hessian vanishes and the estimator is exactly unbiased for all n .

3 Introducing Missingness

3.1 Motivation & Missingness-Mechanisms

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3.2 Amplitude Modulation

Definition of the observation process

To model the missingness, the concept of **amplitude modulation** is employed. This approach models missingness through a binary stochastic process $(O_t)_t$ that runs concurrently with the main process $(X_t)_t$ and modulates its "amplitude" in a binary manner:

$$O_t \in \{0, 1\} \quad \forall t$$

where $O_t = 1$ indicates that X_t is fully observed (amplitude = 1), and $O_t = 0$ indicates that X_t is missing (amplitude = 0).

The amplitude modulating process O_t can be:

- **Deterministic:** For each t , $O_t = o_t$ where $o_t \in \{0, 1\}$ is a known, fixed value.
- **Stochastic:** O_t follows a probability distribution with $\pi_t := P(O_t = 1)$, possibly dependent on the history of X_t , O_t , or external factors.

Bias of the naive estimator

The amplitude modulation is applied to the binarization vector $\mathbf{Z}_t$ to obtain the observable process $(O_t \mathbf{Z}_t)$. We then define the naive estimator of $\mathbf{f}$ as:

$$\hat{\mathbf{f}} := \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n O_t \mathbf{Z}_t.$$

To assess the performance of this naive estimator we compute its expectation

$$\mathbb{E}[\hat{\mathbf{f}}] = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbb{E}[O_t \mathbf{Z}_t] = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbb{E}[\mathbf{Z}_t \mathbb{E}[O_t | \mathbf{Z}_t]],$$

where the last equality follows from the law of iterated expectations.

The dependence structure between $(O_t)_t$ and $(\mathbf{Z}_t)_t$ (or equivalently $(X_t)_t$) is crucial.

Under the assumption of independence, the expression simplifies to

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbb{E}[\mathbf{Z}_t \mathbb{E}[O_t | \mathbf{Z}_t]] = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbb{E}[\mathbf{Z}_t] \mathbb{E}[O_t] = \left(\frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbb{E}[O_t] \right) \mathbf{f}$$

The missingness corrected estimator

Definition 3.1 (Corrected Estimator of $\mathbf{f}$). Since $\mathbb{E}[\hat{\mathbf{f}}]$ deviates from $\mathbf{f}$ by the factor $\frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbb{E}[O_t]$, the corrected estimator of $\mathbf{f}$ is defined as

$$\hat{\mathbf{f}}^* := \frac{\frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n O_t \mathbf{Z}_t}{\frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n O_t} =: \frac{\hat{\mathbf{f}}}{\bar{O}}.$$

Under the assumption of the independence of (O_t) and (X_t) , the stochastic properties of the corrected estimator $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$ can be studied. If (O_t) is deterministic, then $\mathbb{E}[O_t] = o_t \in \{0, 1\}$ for any given t . It follows that

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbb{E}[O_t] = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n O_t = \bar{O},$$

and therefore, here $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^* = \hat{\mathbf{f}}/\bar{O}$ is a perfectly unbiased estimator of $\mathbf{f}$. However, if O_t is a stochastic process then $\mathbb{E}[O_t] = \pi_t \in (0, 1]$ and

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbb{E}[O_t] = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \pi_t \neq \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n O_t = \bar{O},$$

to where $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$ is generally biased.

3.3 Asymptotic Theory for the corrected estimator

The extended process - stationarity and α -mixing

To study this bias we assume (O_t) and (X_t) to be stationary and α -mixing with exponentially decaying coefficients, with $\mathbb{E}[O_t] = \pi$ and a autocovariance function $\gamma_O(h) := \text{Cov}[O_h, O_0]$ and joint expectations $\pi(h) := \mathbb{E}[O_h O_0] = \gamma_O(h) + \pi^2$. To study the joint asymptotic distribution of the estimator $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$, we introduce the extended binary vectors in order to derive the joint asymptotic distribution of all sample averages entering its definition:

$$\mathbf{Z}_t^* := (O_t, O_t Z_{t,0}, \dots, O_t Z_{t,m-1})^\top = O_t (1, \mathbf{Z}_t^\top)^\top,$$

where the elements of $\mathbf{Z}_t^*$ are numbered as $Z_{t,-1}^*, Z_{t,0}^*, \dots, Z_{t,m-1}^*$. The expectation of $\mathbf{Z}_t^*$ is given by

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[\mathbf{Z}_t^*] &= (\mathbb{E}[O_t], \mathbb{E}[O_t Z_{t,0}], \dots, \mathbb{E}[O_t Z_{t,m-1}])^\top \\ &= (\mathbb{E}[O_t], \mathbb{E}[O_t] \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,0}], \dots, \mathbb{E}[O_t] \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,m-1}])^\top && \text{(Independence)} \\ &= (\pi, \pi f_0, \dots, \pi f_{m-1})^\top \\ &= \pi (1, \mathbf{f}^\top)^\top =: \boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}_t^*}. \end{aligned}$$

Since the processes (O_t) and $(\mathbf{Z}_t)$ are independent and stationary, the joint process $((O_t, \mathbf{Z}_t)^\top)$ is also stationary. Moreover, if both processes are α -mixing, then the joint process is α -mixing. As $\mathbf{Z}_t^*$ is a measurable function of $(O_t, \mathbf{Z})^\top$ it follows that $\mathbf{Z}_t^*$ is stationary and α -mixing (with exponentially decaying coefficients).

Multivariate CLT

To study the asymptotic properties of $\mathbf{Z}_t^*$ we once again use Cramer-Wold. Let

$$U_t^* = \mathbf{a}^\top \mathbf{Z}_t^*, \quad \mathbf{a} \in \mathbb{R}^{m+1}.$$

The argument for why U_t^* satisfies the conditions of Ibragimovs CLT is the same as in the argument for why the linear projections of the non-missing estimator $\hat{\mathbf{f}}_t$ converge: Since $U_t^* = \mathbf{a}^\top \mathbf{Z}_t^*$ is a measurable function of the strictly stationary and α -mixing process $\mathbf{Z}_t^*$, it inherits both properties, with $\alpha_{U_t^*}(n) \leq \alpha_{\mathbf{Z}_t^*}(n) \leq C\rho^n$ following from the inclusion $\sigma(U_t^*) \subset \sigma(\mathbf{Z}_t^*)$. The summability condition therefore holds by the same geometric series argument as before. Finally, since each $Z_{t,i}^* \in \{0, 1\}$, the projection U_t^* is bounded and all moments are finite. It follows that. It follows that

$$\sqrt{n}(\bar{U}_t^* - \mu_{U_t^*}) \xrightarrow[n \rightarrow \infty]{d} \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_a^*)$$

where $\mu_{U_t^*} = \mathbb{E}(U_t) = \mathbf{a}^\top \boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}_t^*}$ and

$$\sigma_a^* = \text{Var}(U_t^*) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \text{Cov}(U_t, U_{t+h})$$

$$\text{where } \text{Var}(U_t^*) = \mathbf{a}^\top \text{Var}(\mathbf{Z}_t^*) \mathbf{a} = \sum_{i,j=-1}^{m-1} a_{i+1} a_{j+1} \text{Cov}(Z_{t,i}^*, Z_{t,j}^*)$$

$$\text{and } \text{Cov}(U_t^*, U_{t+h}^*) = \mathbf{a}^\top \text{Cov}(\mathbf{Z}_t^*, \mathbf{Z}_{t+h}^{*\top}) \mathbf{a}$$

$$\text{such that } \sigma_a^* = \mathbf{a}^\top (\text{Var}(\mathbf{Z}_t^*) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \text{Cov}(\mathbf{Z}_t^*, \mathbf{Z}_{t+h}^*)) \mathbf{a}.$$

Since every linear projection U_t^* is asymptotically normal we can follow that the sample mean

$$\bar{\mathbf{Z}}_n^* := \frac{1}{n} \sum_{t=1}^n \mathbf{Z}_t^*$$

satisfies the multivariate CLT

$$\sqrt{n}(\bar{\mathbf{Z}}_n^* - \boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}_t^*}) \xrightarrow[n \rightarrow \infty]{d} \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\mathbf{Z}^*})$$

where $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\mathbf{Z}^*}$ must satisfy for all $\mathbf{a} \in \mathbb{R}^{m+1}$

$$\mathbf{a}^\top \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\mathbf{Z}^*} \mathbf{a} = \sigma_a^* = \mathbf{a}^\top (\text{Var}(\mathbf{Z}_t^*) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \text{Cov}(\mathbf{Z}_t^*, \mathbf{Z}_{t+h}^*)) \mathbf{a}$$

which indicates

$$\Sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*} = \text{Var}(\mathbf{Z}_t^*) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \text{Cov}(\mathbf{Z}_t^*, \mathbf{Z}_{t+h}^*).$$

The individual elements of $\Sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*}$ are given by

(i) $i = j = -1$:

$$\text{Var}(O_t) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \text{Cov}(O_t, O_{t+h}) = \pi(1 - \pi) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \gamma_O(h)$$

(ii) $j > i = -1$:

$$\begin{aligned} & \text{Cov}(O_t, O_t Z_{t,j}) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \text{Cov}(O_t, O_{t+h} Z_{t+h,j}) \\ & \stackrel{\perp}{=} \left(\mathbb{E}[O_t^2] \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,j}] - \mathbb{E}[O_t]^2 \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,j}] \right) \\ & \quad + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \left(\mathbb{E}[O_t O_{t+h}] \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,j}] - \mathbb{E}[O_t]^2 \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,j}] \right) \\ & \stackrel{O_t \in \{0,1\}}{=} (\pi - \pi^2) f_j + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} (\gamma_O(h) + \pi^2 - \pi^2) f_j \\ & = \pi(1 - \pi) f_j + 2 f_j \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \gamma_O(h) = f_j \left(\pi(1 - \pi) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \gamma_O(h) \right) = f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; -1, -1} \end{aligned}$$

(iii) $i, j \geq 0$:

$$\begin{aligned} & \text{Cov}(O_t Z_{t,i}, O_t Z_{t,j}) + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} [\text{Cov}(O_t Z_{t,i}, O_{t+h} Z_{t+h,j}) + \text{Cov}(O_{t+h} Z_{t+h,i}, O_t Z_{t,j})] \\ & \stackrel{\perp}{=} (\mathbb{E}[O_t^2] \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,i} Z_{t,j}] - \pi^2 f_i f_j) \\ & \quad + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} [\mathbb{E}[O_t O_{t+h}] \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,i} Z_{t+h,j}] - \pi^2 f_i f_j + \mathbb{E}[O_t O_{t+h}] \mathbb{E}[Z_{t,j} Z_{t+h,i}] - \pi^2 f_i f_j] \\ & = \pi f_{\min\{i,j\}} - \pi^2 f_i f_j + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \pi(h) f_{ij}(h) + \pi(h) f_{ji}(h) - 2\pi^2 f_i f_j \\ & = \pi f_{\min\{i,j\}} - \pi^2 f_i f_j + \pi f_i f_j - \pi f_i f_j \\ & \quad + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \pi(h) f_{ij}(h) + \pi(h) f_{ji}(h) - 2\pi^2 f_i f_j - 2\gamma(h) f_i f_j + 2\gamma(h) f_i f_j \\ & = \pi(f_{\min\{i,j\}} - f_i f_j) + \left(\pi(1 - \pi) + 2 \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \gamma(h) \right) f_i f_j + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \pi(h) (f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j) \\ & = f_i f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; -1, -1} + \pi(f_{\min\{i,j\}} - f_i f_j) + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \pi(h) (f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j) \end{aligned}$$

To now derive the asymptotic properties of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$ we define the vector-valued function $\mathbf{g} := [0, 1]^{m+1} \rightarrow [0, 1]^m$ as

$$g_j(x_{-1}, x_0, \dots, x_{m-1}) = x_j / x_{-1}, \quad \text{for } j = 0 \dots, m-1,$$

such that

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{g}(\bar{\mathbf{Z}}_t^*) &= (g_0(\bar{\mathbf{Z}}_t^*), \dots, g_{m-1}(\bar{\mathbf{Z}}_t^*))^\top = (\hat{f}_0 O_t / O_t, \dots, \hat{f}_{m-1} O_t / O_t)^\top \\ &= \hat{\mathbf{f}}^* \end{aligned}$$

and accordingly

$$g(\bar{\boldsymbol{\mu}}_{\mathbf{Z}^*}^*) = \mathbf{f}.$$

The Jacobian matrix of $\mathbf{g}(\mathbf{x})$ evaluated at $\mathbf{x} = \boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}^*}$ is given by

$$\mathbf{G}_{(m+1) \times m} = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{\partial g_0(\boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}^*})}{\partial x_{-1}} & \cdots & \frac{\partial g_0(\boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}^*})}{\partial x_{m-1}} \\ \vdots & \cdots & \vdots \\ \frac{\partial g_{m-1}(\boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}^*})}{\partial x_{-1}} & \cdots & \frac{\partial g_{m-1}(\boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}^*})}{\partial x_{m-1}} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} -\frac{f_0}{\pi} & \frac{1}{\pi} & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ -\frac{f_1}{\pi} & 0 & \frac{1}{\pi} & \ddots & \vdots \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & 0 \\ -\frac{f_{m-1}}{\pi} & 0 & \cdots & 0 & \frac{1}{\pi} \end{pmatrix}$$

Then, following the deltamethod, we have the following result

Theorem 3.2 (Asymptotic Normality of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$). *Let (X_t) be a strictly stationary, ordinal process that is α -mixing with exponentially decaying coefficients. Let the modulating process (O_t) also be strictly stationary and α -mixing with exponentially decaying coefficients, with moments $E[O_t] = \pi > 0$ and $E[O_h O_0] = \pi(h) > 0$. Furthermore, let (O_t) and (X_t) be independent, where X_t is observed if $O_t = 1$. Then the corrected estimator from definition 3.1 satisfies the following multivariate CLT:*

$$\sqrt{n}(\hat{\mathbf{f}}^* - \mathbf{f}) \xrightarrow[n \rightarrow \infty]{d} \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*}), \quad \text{with } \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*} = (\sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*; i, j})_{i, j=0, \dots, m-1}, \quad (3.1)$$

where

$$\sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*; i, j} = \frac{1}{\pi}(f_{\min\{i, j\}} - f_i f_j) + \frac{1}{\pi^2} \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \pi(h)(f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j). \quad (3.2)$$

The structure of $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*}$ can be computed as follows

$$\begin{aligned} \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*} &= \mathbf{G} \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\mathbf{Z}^*} \mathbf{G}^\top \\ &= \begin{pmatrix} -\frac{f_0}{\pi} & \frac{1}{\pi} & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ -\frac{f_1}{\pi} & 0 & \frac{1}{\pi} & \ddots & \vdots \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & 0 \\ -\frac{f_{m-1}}{\pi} & 0 & \cdots & 0 & \frac{1}{\pi} \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; -1, -1} & \cdots & \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; -1, m-1} \\ \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; m-1, -1} & \cdots & \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; m-1, m-1} \end{pmatrix} \mathbf{G}^\top \\ &= \begin{pmatrix} -\frac{f_0}{\pi} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; -1, -1} + \frac{1}{\pi} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; 0, -1} & \cdots & -\frac{f_0}{\pi} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; -1, m-1} + \frac{1}{\pi} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; 0, m-1} \\ \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ -\frac{f_{m-1}}{\pi} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; -1, -1} + \frac{1}{\pi} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; m-1, -1} & \cdots & -\frac{f_{m-1}}{\pi} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; -1, m-1} + \frac{1}{\pi} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*; m-1, m-1} \end{pmatrix} \mathbf{G}^\top. \end{aligned}$$

Such that the individual lements look like this:

$$\begin{aligned}
\sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*;i,j} &= \left(-\frac{f_j}{\pi}\right)\left(-\frac{f_i}{\pi}\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} + \frac{1}{\pi}\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;i,-1}\right) + \frac{1}{\pi}\left(-\frac{f_i}{\pi}\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,j} + \frac{1}{\pi}\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;i,j}\right) \\
&= \frac{f_j f_i}{\pi^2}\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} - \frac{f_j}{\pi^2}\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;i,-1} - \frac{f_i}{\pi^2}\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,j} + \frac{1}{\pi^2}\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;i,j} \\
&= \frac{1}{\pi^2} (f_i f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} - f_i f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;i,-1} - f_i f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,j} + \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;i,j}) = \frac{1}{\pi^2} (\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;i,j} - f_i f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1}) \\
&= \frac{1}{\pi^2} \left(\left[f_i f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} + \pi(f_{\min\{i,j\}} - f_i f_j) + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \pi(h) f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j \right] - f_i f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} \right) \\
&= \frac{1}{\pi} \underbrace{(f_{\min\{i,j\}} - f_i f_j)}_{\text{lag}(0)} + \underbrace{\sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \pi(h) (f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j)}_{\text{lag}(h)}
\end{aligned}$$

Here, the lag-0 term captures the contemporaneous covariance structure of the observed process, while the lag- h terms accumulate the serial dependence across all lags $h \geq 1$.

Bias analysis

Since g_j is not a linear function of $\mathbf{Z}_t^*$, the bias of order $O(n^{-1})$ is computable using a second-order Taylor expansion. The Hessian of g_j evaluated in $\boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}^*}$ is given by

$$\mathbf{H}_{g_j} = \left(\frac{\partial^2 g_j(\boldsymbol{\mu}_{\mathbf{Z}^*})}{\partial x_i \partial x_k} \right)_{i,k=-1,\dots,m-1} = \begin{cases} \frac{2f_j}{\pi^2} & \text{if } i = k = -1 \\ -\frac{1}{\pi^2} & \text{if } i = -1, k = j \\ 0 & \text{else.} \end{cases}$$

Since only two entries of $\mathbf{H}_{g_j}$ are nonzero, and using the symmetry $\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,j} = \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;j,-1}$, the bias reduces to

$$\begin{aligned}
\text{Bias}(\hat{f}_j) &= \frac{1}{2} \text{tr}(\mathbf{H}_{g_j} \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\mathbf{Z}^*}) \\
&= \frac{1}{2} h_{g_j;-1,-1} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} + h_{g_j;-1,j} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,j} \\
&= \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{2f_j}{\pi^2} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} - \frac{1}{\pi^2} \cdot f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} \\
&= \frac{f_j}{\pi^2} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} - \frac{f_j}{\pi^2} \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1} = 0,
\end{aligned}$$

where the last step uses $\sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,j} = f_j \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}^*;-1,-1}$ from case (ii) of $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}_{\mathbf{Z}^*}$.

Special Cases

To further study the asymptotic distribution of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$, we consider three special cases of the general result.

Corollary 3.3 (Full Observation). *If the process is fully observed, i.e. $\pi = 1$, then*

$$\sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*; i, j} = (f_{\min\{i, j\}} - f_i f_j) + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j = \sigma_{\mathbf{Z}; i, j}.$$

That is, the asymptotic covariance of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$ reduces to that of the complete-data estimator $\hat{\mathbf{f}}$, as one would expect.

Corollary 3.4 (i.i.d. Observation Process). *If (O_t) is i.i.d., then $\pi(h) = \pi^2$ for all $h \geq 1$, and the asymptotic covariance simplifies to*

$$\sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*; i, j} = \frac{1}{\pi} (f_{\min\{i, j\}} - f_i f_j) + \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j.$$

Compared to the complete-data case, the lag-0 term is inflated by a factor of $1/\pi \geq 1$, reflecting the additional uncertainty introduced by the random missingness. The lag- h terms for $h \geq 1$, however, are unaffected, since i.i.d. missingness introduces no additional serial dependence into the observation process.

Corollary 3.5 (i.i.d. Main Process). *If (X_t) is i.i.d., then $f_{ij}(h) = f_i f_j$ for all $i, j = 0, \dots, m-1$ and $h \geq 1$, so that the asymptotic covariance reduces to*

$$\sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*; i, j} = \frac{1}{\pi} (f_{\min\{i, j\}} - f_i f_j) + \frac{1}{\pi^2} \sum_{h=1}^{\infty} \pi(h) \overbrace{(f_{ij}(h) + f_{ji}(h) - 2f_i f_j)}^{=0} = \frac{1}{\pi} (f_{\min\{i, j\}} - f_i f_j).$$

When the main process is serially independent, all temporal dependence in $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$ vanishes and the asymptotic covariance only depends on the lag-0 term.

3.4 Asymptotic marginal properties

The asymptotic properties of marginal statistics based on $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$ follow directly from the delta method, in exact analogy to the complete-data case. The following corollaries state the results for the IOV and the Skew. However, the derivations for other marginal statistics are

Corollary 3.6 (Asymptotic distribution of $\text{IOV}(\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*)$). *Under the conditions of Theorem 3.2, the delta-method argument from Theorem 2.4 carries over to the missing-data case with Σ_Z replaced by $\Sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*}$, yielding*

$$\text{Var}(\text{IOV}(\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*)) \stackrel{\text{asy.}}{=} \frac{16}{m^2} \sum_{i, j=0}^{m-1} (1 - 2f_i)(1 - 2f_j) \sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*; i, j}.$$

Moreover, since $\mathbf{H}_{\text{IOV}} = -\frac{8}{m} \mathbf{I}_m$ remains diagonal, the bias to order n^{-1} depends only on the marginal variances of $\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*$:

$$\text{Bias}(\text{IOV}(\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*)) = -\frac{4}{mn} \sum_{i=0}^{m-1} \sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*; i, i} + o(n^{-1}).$$

Remark 3.7 (Skew under missingness). The analogous result for the skew follows immediately, since the skew is linear in $\mathbf{f}$ and hence $\mathbf{H}_{\text{skew}} = 0$. In particular, the estimator is asymptotically unbiased and its variance is given by

$$\text{Var}(\text{skew}(\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*)) \stackrel{\text{asy.}}{=} \frac{4}{m^2 n} \sum_{i,j=0}^{m-1} \sigma_{\hat{\mathbf{f}}^*; i,j}.$$